

Week 1

Introduction to Civics and citizenship

Civics:

The word CIVICS has been derived from two Latin words CIVITAS & CIVIS, which means citizens or citizenship. It means CIVICS is a discipline of knowledge dealing with day-to-day affairs of the state and its citizens. CIVICS claims that an individual must be aware of his rights, duties and social responsibilities to create better society.

Civics is the study of the rights, duties, and responsibilities of citizens in a society. It focuses on how people interact with the government, how the government works, and what it means to be a responsible citizen. Civics helps people understand their role in making a community, country, or even the world a better place by participating in the political process, obeying laws, and respecting the rights of others.

E.M White defines Civics as a useful discipline of human knowledge, which deals with every aspect of human life covering his past, present and future aspects at local, national and global levels.

Frederick James Gold

"The study of institutions, habits and spirits by means of which a man or woman (citizens) may fulfill the duties and receive the benefits of membership in political community".

Importance Of Civics

Its importance is further elaborated through the following points:

- ▶ **POLITICAL TRAINING:** Civics leads a man towards the basic knowledge about Political process such as voting, elections system & responsibilities of government. This also helps man about the detailed knowledge of rights and duties of individuals within a society.
- ▶ **DEVELOPMENT OF A GOOD SOCIETY:** An individual and a society are inter-dependent. Civics explains the linkages between individual and various social institutions. A good society, ultimately, depends upon good individuals, and this is CIVICS, which modifies collective approach and attitudes. This creates the sentiments of mutual cooperation, partnership, sacrifice a sympathy among individuals, and plays an effective role in eliminating moral problems and issues.

- ▶ **MORAL TRAINING:** Good and Bad both forces are present in a man's person, stronger of which forces him to be inclined to a particular character. Additionally, his environment also influences his behavior.
- ▶ **SUCCESS OF DEMOCRATIC SYSTEM:** Democracy has a special significance among various political systems. It is required for the success of democratic process to teach this subject to the individuals of the society so that they can develop into good citizens through enlightenment about the system of the rights and duties. The success of democratic system depends upon the people charged with the emotions of social service, civic sense and dutifulness. To make it a success, CIVICS plays a vital role.
- ▶ **SOLUTION OF SOCIAL ISSUES:** This subject has the potential of solving social and cultural issues. With the help of this knowledge, people can keep their civic and material environment neat and clean, because it teaches man to lead a life according to healthy tradition. This inculcates, among peoples, such capabilities, which enables them to curb all types of social evils.
- ▶ **AWARENESS ABOUT NATIONAL ISSUES:** Government cannot solve many of the problems without public cooperation. Health and cleanliness, promotion of education, eliminating unemployment and support of needy people are the best examples of such problems, because these directly influence collective life and hence, hinder national progress. CIVICS helps man in solving such problems by teaching him self-support and taking it as the back force for the solution of various Social and economic problems.
- ▶ **PROMOTION OF INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS:** Scientific advancement has brought people of various corners of the globe closer to each other. Now, they are in better position to help each other in national uplift. The citizens of the day are also reluctant to keep their affairs to be limited to their selves. He rather wants to be updated with the global matters. This is CIVICS, which enables him to contribute in maintaining world peace through the development of healthy relation with international communities.

Utility of Civics

- ▶ **AWARENESS ABOUT SOCIAL ISSUES:** Many of the social issues have direct impact on human life. So, the knowledge of various other social sciences supplements the study of CIVICS to much extent. This subject gives, its student, a sense of social issues along with the strong urge for their solution.
- ▶ **AWARENESS ABOUT RIGHTS & DUTIES:** CIVICS emphasizes and exclusive study of human rights and duties / responsibilities. None can get any benefit out of his rights unless he is

well versed with the knowledge of a sound distribution of rights and duties. After this awareness an individual can execute his citizenship effectively.

- ▶ **AWARENESS ABOUT NATIONAL POLITICS:** People are involved in decision making about national politics and system of government. This is the demand of this age of democracy. They can play a positive role in this regard only if they have a sound knowledge and full awareness about the political theories and their practical aspects about their country. This is the study of CIVICS, which equips them with the required knowledge as it encircles voting system, system of government, types of elections (direct or indirect) and the responsibilities of elected government. Hence a man can better execute the responsibilities of voting, abiding by national rules and regulations, only if he has a sound CIVIC background.
- ▶ **AWARENESS ABOUT INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS:** The present scientific and technological advancement has much increased the mutual relations of the citizens of different states. A global community has been developed and its significance is increasing every day. Economic, political and cultural relations between various countries are getting stronger and stronger. This concept of global citizenship helps an individual in getting rid of regional and local prejudices and makes him an effective member of global society. This helps him in the development of the zeal of coordination and cooperation with the people of the other nations. The knowledge of the international affairs, issues and institutions required for this purpose come from a sound study of CIVICS.
- ▶ **AWARENESS ABOUT ECONOMIC AFFAIRS:** CIVICS enables a person to know about economic issues of his own country along with those of other nations. This discipline provides a person with the basic information about the economic affairs directly influence the person. The study of various global economic concepts and theories are very much therein the canvas of CIVICS. This helps a man in learning about dignity of labor the just means of earning livelihood.
- ▶ **DEVELOPMENT OF HEALTHY HABITS:** The study of CIVICS enables a person to believe in brotherhood, virtues, sympathetic approach and unity. In this way this subject includes good habits among individual highlighting his good characteristics and, develops him into a healthy personality.
- ▶ **SOCIAL WELFARE:** The study of CIVICS develops feelings in the individual about social welfare and consequently the man gets prepared to cooperate with the government in related activities. This further leads towards development of a healthy society, which is possible only when individuals, for any virtue, do not wait for the advice or the orders of government, rather they help the government voluntarily.

Citizenship:

Citizenship refers to the status of being a legally recognized member of a country, which grants individuals specific rights and responsibilities. This status typically includes the right to participate in the political process, such as voting and running for office, as well as responsibilities like obeying the laws, paying taxes, and contributing to the welfare of the community. Citizenship establishes a formal relationship between the individual and the state, defining both the protections and obligations of the person within that nation.

Types of Citizenship:

There are several types of citizenship, each based on different principles.

Jus Soli (Right of the Soil): Citizenship based on the place where a person is born called Jus Soli. In Pakistan, jus soli is not widely applied. For instance, In the United States, citizenship is primarily based on jus soli. This means that anyone born on U.S. soil is automatically a U.S. citizen. For example, a child born in New York to non-American parents is a U.S.

The UK does not generally follow jus soli. A child born in the UK to non-British parents does not automatically gain British citizenship unless at least one parent is a British citizen or settled in the UK.

Jus Sanguinis (Right of Blood): Citizenship based on the nationality of one's parents is called Jus Sanguinis. In Pakistan, a child born to Pakistani parents, born in Pakistan or abroad, is generally considered a Pakistani citizen. The U.S. also uses jus sanguinis to determine citizenship. A child born abroad to American citizens is considered a U.S. citizen, provided at least one parent has been a U.S citizen for a certain period and meets other legal requirements.

Naturalization: is the process through which someone who is not originally a citizen of a country becomes a citizen of that country. It involves going through specific legal procedures, such as applying for citizenship, meeting certain requirements (like residency and knowledge of the country's language and laws), and taking an oath of allegiance.

Double Citizenship: -The question of double citizenship arises when a child born in any other country gets its citizenship automatically. For example, a child born with Pakistani parents in UK, will become citizen of Pakistan by Blood Relationship while he gets citizenship of UK by the principle of "Place of Birth". When such children get mature, they have a choice to opt the citizenship of any of the two countries.

GOOD CITIZENSHIP

Lord Bryce has indicated three major qualities of a good citizen. These are:

WISDOM: According to Lord Bryce wisdom that quality through which the citizens must be able to think and understand the affairs related to their country. They should be enlightened to such an extent that they possess a confidence of decision making. This helps them in having proper understanding about the needs of their homeland and can properly use their right of voting to elect honest and capable people, who can shoulder the political responsibility. Their wisdom helps them in proper selection of the representatives to the legislative. By showing sensible approach towards national affairs, people prove to be good citizens and ensure a successful political process in the country.

SELF DISCIPLINE: Self-discipline is the second most important quality of a good citizen. An individual (citizen) has to prove to be self-disciplined in many ways at many occasions. For example, abiding by the state regulations, preferring national interests over personal ones, using legal process to win public opinion and many similar activities need self-discipline of a citizen.

BROADMINDEDNESS: According to Lord Bryce, broadmindedness is one of the three basic characteristics required by a good citizen. Broadminded citizens pay all their national duties with a high sense of responsibility, honesty and vigor. With this quality all other responsibilities can also be executed properly and readily. A good human being only, can be good citizen and the broadmindedness is the most basic characteristic of a good human being. If the citizens of a state are of high moral and conscious approach, other required qualities of a good citizen can automatically be inculcated in their person. These are basic characteristics of a good citizen and make him a sensible, dutiful and respectable individual.

HINDRANCES TO GOOD CITIZENSHIP

The factors, which can hinder: a good citizenship, are given below:

- **MORAL DETERIORATION:** When moral standards of a society deteriorate, the members of such society cannot be good citizens. Patriotism, honesty, devoted labor, selfless thoughts, practicality and above all proving to be broadmindedness is possible only if people honor moral values and prepared to mend their attitudes in accordance with those moral principles. Morally low mentality has a tendency of denial from national duties. Such people can scarify national objective for petty personal gains. Dishonesty, breach trust, voting for material gain, committing crimes etc. are not impossible for such low mentality people. So, expecting good citizenship from such individuals is not justified.
- **IGNORANCE:** Knowledge is light which gives vision and wisdom 10 men. A person equipped with knowledge and awareness about rights and duties, can equip himself with

the qualities of a good citizen, while person having no clear idea about rights and duties, and knowing nothing about his national issues is just a burden on the country. Hence ignorance and illiteracy are the biggest hurdles in becoming good citizens. Being ignorant none can improve his wisdom and political awareness, neither can he develop his qualities of selflessness, self-discipline and honesty.

- **SELFISHNESS:** No individual can become a good citizen unless he can scarify his personal interests on those of the nation. Self-discipline is the most crucial requirement for being good citizens. Those who opt dishonesty for petty and personal gains against national interest, cause the destruction of social and political life.
- **BIASES AMONG POLITICAL PARTIES:** Political parties are a necessity of democratic form of government, which are supposed to be a source of achieving national objections. So the political parties should be used for meeting the national objectives and not for any personal ones, having being above all the biases. If in a society individual differences are made a base for grouping and mutual hatred, this situation leads toward chaos. In this way political parties cause a big hurdle in becoming good citizens.

Civic Engagement: Civic engagement means actively participating in activities that improve your community or society. It involves people working together to make a difference in the lives of others and in how the government works. Civic engagement can take many forms, such as voting, volunteering, attending community meetings, or joining local organizations to address social issues.

Types of citizenship as Community Engagement:

Active Citizenship: Active citizens are those who get involved in their community and work to improve it. They take responsibility and take action to solve problems. A person who votes in every election, volunteers at a local charity, or helps organize community events is an active citizen.

Digital citizenship: It refers to using the internet and social media responsibly to engage in civic activities, share opinions; and stay informed. Someone, who uses social media to raise awareness about social issues, supports online petitions, or participates in virtual campaigns is practicing digital citizenship.

Economic Citizenship: It involves being aware of how your financial decisions and work impact society and the economy. Paying taxes, supporting fair trade, or advocating for workers' rights are examples of economic citizenship.

Democracy and Citizenship:

Democracy and citizenship are closely connected because both deal with the role of people in shaping the government and society. In a democracy, citizens' have specific rights and responsibilities that allow them to participate in governing their country. Citizenship gives people the legal status to take part in democratic processes, like voting and influencing decisions. On the other hand, democracy provides the system in which citizens can have their voices heard and their rights protected.

Here's a detailed explanation of the relationship between democracy and citizenship

Democracy is a system of government where power belongs to the people. In democratic countries, citizens participate in the political process by: Voting in elections to choose their leaders. Making decisions about laws and policies that affect their lives. Having the freedom to speak, assemble, and express opinions without fear. The most important feature of democracy is that the government is accountable to the people. Leaders must respect the will of the majority, but they also have to protect the rights of minorities.

The relationship between democracy and citizenship is essential because, in a democracy, citizens are the core of the political system. Democracy depends on active and informed citizens who participate in the political process.

Conclusion:

Civics and citizenship play a vital role in developing responsible, aware, and active members of society. Through the study of civics, individuals understand their rights, duties, and responsibilities, which helps in building good citizenship. Active civic engagement and moral values strengthen democratic systems. Therefore, informed and disciplined citizens are essential for the success of democracy and the progress of society.